The Stages of Coemergent Yoga

Sahajayogakrama · Toh 1246 · Derge Tengyur
ལྷན་ཅིག་སྐྱེས་པའི་རྣལ་འབྱོར་བཀྲ་རིམ་པ

The Stages of Coemergent Yoga, known in Sanskrit as the Sahajayogakrama and in Tibetan as Lhenchik Kyepé Naljor gyi Rimpa, is a short meditation manual on the completion stage of the Hevajra tantra, composed by the great Indian master Ratnākaraśānti and translated into Tibetan by Kumārakalaśa. Opening with homage to Hevajra and to the wheel of yoginīs, it explains coemergent joy as the culmination of tantric practice, identifying its result with the dharmakāya and sambhogakāya and with nondual gnosis that is great bliss. It then sets out how the practitioner, visualizing himself as Heruka united with Nairātmyā, turns toward the ultimate, extends that bliss to all things, alternates equipoise with post-meditation, and passes through four progressively clearer phases likened to a cloud, an illusion, a dream, and sleep and waking. The work is Toh 1246 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the commentaries on the tantras.

In the language of India: sahajasayoga kramanāma. In the language of Tibet: The Stages of Coemergent Yoga.

Homage to glorious Hevajra.

Bowing deeply to the sublime wheel of yoginīs,
Together with Hevajra, its concordant cause,
I shall explain, just as it is,
The realization on the side of the completion stage.

Having imagined the sphere of space as the bhaga,
One should meditate in its center:
With the wheel preceding, as is fitting,
How the deities arose.

This is the brief teaching. Its meaning is as follows:

Once the agent has entered the abode,
The practitioner should perform the act.
The result is the wheel of yoginīs;
Its concordant cause is Heruka.

Here, of the four purities on the side of generation, the third, which is below the supreme and above the joy of cessation, is the coemergent joy. That itself is here twofold:

The result is held to be twofold:
One is like space,
The other like the full moon.
Of these, that which is like space
Is the dharmakāya of the Protector;
That which resembles the full moon
Is the sambhogakāya.
That itself is the wheel of yoginīs,
Which is nondual gnosis.
Just as at the end it is great bliss,
So at the beginning it is not different.
It is the intrinsic nature of all phenomena,
It is nondual gnosis,
It is great bliss; and therefore
All beings are likewise.

The realization of this is as follows. One who is qualified for this meditation, a hero, alone, dwelling in solitude, should sit on a soft seat and become certain that all phenomena are pure by nature. Conceiving himself as Heruka, he mentally summons any woman whatever and conceives her as Nairātmyā. Then, in the kakkola, the sport of the bola, or else in the opening of the bola, he should meditate on the play of skillful means and wisdom arising from his own heart and navel, and by the power of that meditation he should turn toward the ultimate. Having turned toward it, he should extend it to all the senses, to the limbs and lesser limbs, and to all things of the ten directions.

Without appearance, mere clarity,
Great bliss without limit:
For as long as one is able,
One should behold it without interruption.

On rising, since all things have the nature of great bliss, one should conceive them as having the nature of the wheel of yoginīs. In order to gather swiftly, again and again, the accumulations of merit and gnosis, one should make offerings with that very great bliss of self-awareness. Through this distinctive meditation that gathers the accumulations, one will before long attain the desired accomplishment.

All living beings arose from me;
The three realms, too, arose from me;

All of these are pervaded by me;
No other nature of beings is seen.
The yogin who, knowing thus,
Trains in meditative equipoise,
Even a person of little merit,
Will be accomplished, without doubt.

Or else, there is the yoga of meditative equipoise and the yoga of rising, again and again. These two yogas are to be practiced according to one's ability, like the current of a river, or like the continuous light of a moving lamp:

Always, through that very yoga,
One should abide day and night.

This gnosis of self-awareness
Transcends the domain of the path of speech.
It is the stage of blessing,
The very nature of omniscient gnosis.
Earth and water and fire,
Wind and space themselves:
Knowing all through knowing their nature,
In that instant none of them can harm.
In the heavens, upon the earth, and beneath the earth,
In an instant it becomes a single body;
By concepts that divide natures
It cannot be harmed.

This yoga, by division of phase and division of method, is fourfold: like a cloud, like an illusion, like a dream, and like sleep and waking. Before accomplishment it is like a cloud, because it is not clear, like the full moon veiled by thin cloud. When accomplished it is like an illusion, because it arises clearly through the power of a consort emanated by the mind. Then it resembles a dream, because through the power of the yoga of the syllables of the bola it arises all at once in yogic sleep. Then it is like dream and waking. How is it like waking? Because it arises from union with an outer consort. What is the reason it is like a dream? Because self and other are not apprehended. These, moreover, become progressively more excellent, because each later one arises through the power of each earlier one. How is the last the best of all? Because even when there is distraction and one is not fully in equipoise,

the commitments are present without exception.

From the profoundest Hevajra
I have condensed the practice of the coemergent;
Whatever virtue I have thereby accumulated,
By it may beings attain the state of Vajradhara.

The Sublime Coemergent Yoga, composed by the great master, the glorious Ratnākaraśānti, is complete. It was translated, revised and finalized by the glorious Kumārakalaśa.

Translator's Notes

• Kakkola and bola are tantric code terms for the female and male sexual organs; they are kept untranslated. The Tibetan writes "pola" once and "bola" elsewhere; the evident reading "bola" is followed throughout. The final reason for the superiority of the fourth phase is terse ("even with distraction, not fully in equipoise ... because the commitments are present without exception"); it is rendered as one combined reason, though the two "because" clauses may be intended separately.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.